A complicating factor is the risk of IOs' being co-opted by populists. When populist leaders come to power, they often attempt to install skeptics or loyalists in key IO positions, potentially undermining resistance from within (Bellodi, Morelli, and Vannoni 2024). For example, Donald Trump during his first term appointed David Malpass—an outspoken critic of large financial outlays from IOs—as the head of the World Bank, signaling an intent to reshape the institution's agenda.

Complete bureaucratic overhauls, however, are rare. Populists may lack the political capital or institutional authority to dismantle entrenched IO structures. Moreover, the time and energy required for such efforts can deter even the most determined leaders. As a result, populists often focus on placing allies in high-profile leadership roles while leaving much of the bureaucracy intact. This partial co-optation underscores the resilience of IOs but also highlights the challenges they face in maintaining independence and integrity.

### *2.4.3 Domestic Publics*

We conceptualize domestic publics as individuals with preferences over policies and leaders, though we remain neutral on the origins of these preferences. Decades of research demonstrate that people often develop deep partisan attachments (Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 2002) that frequently guide their approval (or disapproval) of policies and institutions, including IOs (Schlipphak, Meiners, and Kiratli 2022). These attachments mean that political leaders and other elites wield considerable influence over public attitudes toward IOs, shaping narratives that either bolster or undermine support.

However, public opinion isn't solely a reflection of elite cues. Citizens' views can evolve independently, driven by personal experiences, new information, or major events. Leaders, even those with strong support, are not immune to losing public favor as a result of scandals, perceived betrayals, or failure to deliver on promises. In democracies, this risk is particularly acute, as leaders who fail to maintain public backing can be ousted at the ballot box. But even in nondemocratic regimes, public opinion matters; authoritarian leaders often rely on public perception to legitimize their rule and quell dissent. In both cases, citizens act as a check on leaders'